grasped the world with both hands and are devouring it with an insatiable appetite, they are devouring America and have now turned their attention to Iran and still they are not satisfied."[8]

Second, Khomeini propagated the extinction of Israel for religious reasons—as a precondition for Muslim unity and Islamic revival and as a core duty in the struggle against the "moral corruption" embodied by a decadent West. Khomeini drew a direct link between Zionism and secularization and therefore described Israel as the "germ of corruption. . .the destructive impulses of which threaten the entire Islamic world every day."[9] He thus "islamized" the Arab-Israeli conflict by transforming a hitherto political conflict into a struggle between righteousness and falsehood, between pre-modern Islamic culture and cultural Westernization, in which no compromise was possible.[10]

Third, Khomeini also viewed Israel through the prism of the *Protocols of the Elders of Zion*. In a speech in June 1963 he claimed that "Israel. . .wishes to seize your economy, to destroy your trade and agriculture, to appropriate your wealth."[11]

Khomeini was not the first to combine crude antisemitism with anti-Zionism. In 1925, Hitler likewise attacked Zionism in *Mein Kampf*, warning that "a Jewish state in Palestine" would only serve as an "organization centre for their international world-swindling,. . .and a university for up-and-coming swindlers."[12] Fifty years later, Khomeini designated Israel as a "festering sore and a cancerous tumour on the body of the Islamic countries," as a "man-eating giant and a pagan usurper," as a "monster aspiring to world domination," as a "germ of corruption in the heart of the Arab world," and as an "enemy of all mankind." These quotes are taken from a 1996 brochure that was disseminated by the Iranian state in the German language.[13] It is difficult, according to Robert Wistrich, "to imagine a more dehumanizing and repulsive terminology, yet the significance of its usage is widely ignored by the Western world."[14]

After the victory of the revolution in 1979, three major changes took place with regard to Iranian antisemitism.

First, the rhetoric against Jews was toned down. Khomeini could ignore neither the signs of submission given by the Iranian Jewish community nor the precept of *Dhimmitude* laid down in the Koran. In May 1979, he declared: "We distinguish between Jews and Zionists. Zionism has nothing to do with religion."[15] From now on, Jews (like the Armenian Christians and Zoroastrians) were treated as wards of a traditional Islamic state—*Dhimmis*—according to the "principles of Islamic justice." The fundamental antisemitism, however, did not vanish. On the contrary. Iranian copies of the

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